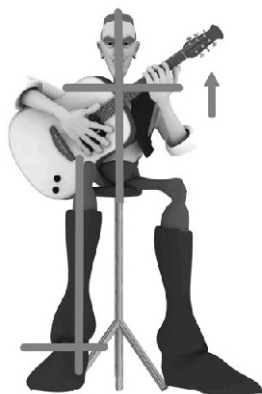


Posture holds a significant role in the development of overall musicians' potential and personality. The posture that is the most natural and comfortable for the body can only complement long hours of playing, practice and right and sincere application of the exercises.

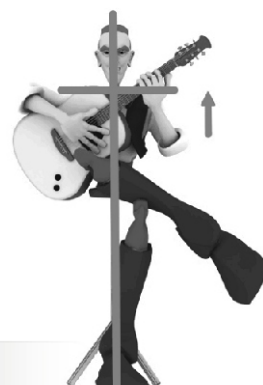
The healthy posture is the most conducive to the physical and mental efficiency of the learner. Though one cannot generalize a single posture as healthy for everyone. The argument behind the fact is the difference of sizes of people's bodies i.e. arms, shoulders, legs, fingers etc without any much difference of sizes in guitar bodies available in the market. There is a great difference between a physically mature tall man holding the guitar and a teenage short girl.

The basic problem appears while holding guitars of different sizes and different weight is the counter effect one requires from the muscles in order to maintain the balance of the guitar against the gravity. So instead of changing the guitar and selecting a lighter or slim shape guitar, one starts adapting its body to maintain the posture. Which always demotivates the beginner, particularly growing teenagers to unable to learn the instrument due to physical stress. It's impossible sometimes to hold the guitar for few minutes due to strain on the neck, shoulder, arms and deformed spine. And as such a 45 minutes session can be a great physical stress and boredom.



Fig# 8.1

Casual Way-1



Fig# 8.2

Casual Way-2

There are two basic postures to hold the guitar. One is the **classic way** and the other is the **casual way**. (We will only be doing casual way in this volume). The casual way is less awkward than the classical one as there is no requirement of the footstool. The two casual positions allow guitar to be kept on the right thigh. The body parts and posture will be like this

Feet will be on the floor making thighs almost parallel to the floor and the guitar will be placed over the right thigh, the back of the guitar will be brought closer to touch the right chest, the legs won't be too wide or too close putting unnecessary strain on holding.

"Hold yours guitar as you hold yours' baby, don't feel it a stranger psychologically"

Body should be kept straight without cheating the right posture; spine should not be sloping down making body less active and less flexible. Shoulders will be relaxed and in parity with each other i.e. in balance. Guitar head can be raised so that it remains in easy accessibility for fingers. Try to make it as natural as possible.

The second ***cross-legged casual position*** substitutes the necessity of a footstool by raising the thigh. Sometimes the chair we choose to sit or play does not allow the thigh to be parallel with the floor. As such in order to adjust we need to raise one foot or may have to use a footstool. The ***cross-legged position*** is helpful in these cases. Remember that the chair one chooses to sit and play guitar should be without arms.

Left hand posture

Left hand also has two basic positions varying as per the styles and techniques to adopt, particularly thumb placement behind the neck.

In the ***first position*** you place yours thumb midway behind the neck i.e. just behind yours fingers at the center of the back of neck. The touch has to be very soft. In this case the ***flexibility, reach and motion of the fingers in coordination with the thumb is maximum***. Wrist is not extra stretched. It helps a lot while changing chords and playing scales smoothly in a relaxed and stress-free state. This position is compulsory in flamenco and classical style playing. This position does not allow flexibility or any choice for the movement of the thumb.



Fig# 8.3



Fig#8.4

The other position is thumb over position and is more general these days except in classical guitar style. Few chords changes and positions sometimes demand this sort of thumb over position. It is also helpful in bending the strings. Wrist is also straighter than in angle.

The fingers need to be arched so that the tips are touching the guitar strings. Fingertips should be placed just behind the fret and not on top of it. Guitar is always played between the frets and not on the frets so the right placement of fingers needs to be just behind the fret. One needs to practice and develop both thumb movements over the Fretboard.

Left-hand holding tips: -

- 1) Don't try to hold neck too hard by squeezing the thumb and changing its natural shape and position.
- 2) Try to maintain holding the neck in the two basic forms and stay relaxed.
- 3) If fingers are allowed to relaxed motion they are automatic in adjustment. Few chord positions are better adjusted by fingers automatically.

Shoulder, forearm, wrist and right-hand position

The ***position of shoulder*** needs to be relaxed i.e. without any tension. It should not be inclined or declined. It should be in balance with the other shoulder neither higher nor lower. The ***forearm placement*** has to be in such a way that the hand lie just over the sound hole and the wrist over bridge. Though guitar sound box comes in different sizes and also size of forearm may vary, so at last everybody needs to adjust a bit. Most important is that the position should be comfortable and not stressful or awkward. Hand and forearm needs to lie in the straight line over the sound hole i.e. hand should not angle down from the wrist area. It allows more comfortable movement of the wrist and avoids unnecessary strain to other muscles.

Things to look for :

- 1) Don't lean either side making yours back to curve.
- 2) Don't slump over the guitar. Keep yours spine as straight as possible.
- 3) Your left hands nails should not protrude beyond yours finger tips.

